



■ By Sharda Ugra in Johannesburg

Youngsters need good techniques, they cannot do that by watching rubbish. There is nothing good about Twenty20 cricket.

—Michael Holding

What is Twenty20? Why not Ten10 or One1?

—BCCI Secretary Niranjan Shah in 2006

I don't think I really like playing Twenty20 international cricket.

—Ricky Ponting in 2006

Eighteen months ago, India didn't think much of Twenty20. When the International Cricket Council (ICC) discussed the first-ever World Twenty20, the Board for Control of Cricket in India (BCCI) had sneered. After all, India was doing fine with its cricket, it had no problem selling television rights or match tickets, and it didn't need a new micromini version of the game. Translated, the question essentially was: what's the logic in settling for 40 overs of commercial television breaks when you could easily sell 100? BCCI was out-voted 9-1 at an ICC meeting in Cape Town, South Africa and Secretary Niranjan Shah had said gloomily, "We had no other go but to embrace the format."

On the evening India won the first World Twenty20 final in Johannesburg, Shah was there, having flown in from a country, which in the course of 10 days, had taken to T20 cricket like a teenager consumed by first love. The horror of the Caribbean World Cup was forgotten, new heroes had held their nerve against quality competition, television rat-

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Twenty20 is car chase cricket, full throttle, with no time or space for hesitation. Packaged with modern bells and whistles, crowds identify with it and respond to its clamour and vibrancy. The Indian victory provided the mandatory happy ending with Shah Rukh Khan in attendance, but the message is clear: we have seen the future of cricket and its name is Twenty20.

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